
INTERNATIONAL A-LEVEL ENGLISH LITERATURE

Unit 4A Literary representations

Thursday 11 January 2024 07:00 GMT Time allowed: 2 hours 30 minutes

Materials

For this paper you must have:

- an OxfordAQA 12-page Answer book.

Instructions

- Use black ink or black ball-point pen.
- Write the information required on the front of your answer book.
- Do all rough work in your answer book. Cross through any work you do not want to be marked.
- You must answer **all** questions. There is **one** question in Section A and **one** question in Section B.

Information

- The maximum mark for this paper is 50.
- The marks for questions are shown in brackets.
- You will be marked on your ability to:
 - use good English
 - organise information clearly
 - analyse carefully the writers' methods
 - use specialist vocabulary where appropriate.

Section A: Prose

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Read the following extract carefully. It is taken from *We That Were Young*, a semi-autobiographical novel by Irene Rathbone, first published in 1932. Joan is a voluntary nurse, or V.A.D., who has been caring for wounded soldiers who have been brought to London. In this extract, set in 1916, she is faced with the challenge of nursing the seriously wounded from the First World War Battle of the Somme.

Write an analysis of this extract, in which you focus on the significance of the representation of the wartime experiences of a young nurse.

[25 marks]

JULY in England. From the Somme battle-fields the convoys of wounded poured into the hospitals. Every bed was full, new wards were being erected, nurses were rushed off their feet, and Joan had enough work at last. She had been sent, at four days' notice, to the 1st London General, Camberwell, and although she had hoped it might be abroad — Egypt or France — she was thankful to be in any military hospital at all.

V.A.D.'s all over the country, whether they had had much, or little, or no training were being called up. From their homes, from their local hospitals, they were flung suddenly into gigantic wards where they had to rise as best they could to the varied and strenuous demands made on them. Whereas hitherto they had been taken in dozens, they were now being taken in hundreds — it seemed almost impossible to obtain a sufficient number; and when there actually appeared an article in *The Times* on the subject, the middle-class, home-sheltered girls of England felt, at last, that their existence was not wholly futile. How different from being merely 'allowed to do things' was the fact of being definitely asked to come and do them. They were in the same position as their brothers now: needed by the country.

In Joan's ward there were forty beds, and almost every patient was seriously wounded. She had never seen anything like the wounds. Many had to be dressed three times a day. It had been one thing to amble in and out of the cosy little wards at the Hampstead hospital, carrying meals, doing housework, and even assisting at the mild dressings; it was quite another here, in Ward 33 of the 1st London General, to see limbs which shrapnel had torn about and swollen into abnormal shapes, from which yellow pus poured when the bandages were removed, which were caked with brown blood, and in whose gangrenous flesh loose bits of bone had to be sought for painfully with probes.

Every night during the first week Joan dreamt about the wounds, saw them floating before her eyes, almost had the stench of them in her nostrils. It was inevitable this should be so, for, during the day, sensibilities had to be hardened, quivering disgust controlled, and head and hand kept steady for the sake of the sufferers themselves. With unconscious wisdom she let down a sort of safety-curtain between her mind and the sights before her, keeping them at bay, preventing their full significance from penetrating. If she had not done so she would have been useless. The nights were reactions from this discipline, and the safety-curtain no longer functioning, the horror rushed in on her in the shape of dreams.

But after the first week she no longer even dreamed. She had adjusted herself inwardly and outwardly to the conditions in which her life must now be lived — conditions which, if they could not be accepted as normal, would mean her defeat. And in the face of the gay endurance, the positively worshipful spirit of the wounded, how was it possible not to give of one's very best?

A fervent emotion — whether towards a person, a country, or a cause — may be able to express itself in a poem, or at any rate some form of words. Happy if it can. But it may also have to be expressed in ways more indirect, and less glowingly satisfactory. Joan's feeling of almost weeping admiration for the men had to show itself in the severest practical form — and this was not easy for her. Mentally she was on her knees to them; actually she was on her feet twelve hours a day, sweeping, washing, bed-making, moving down one long line of iron bedsteads and up another with the wheeled table on which were the appliances for the dressings. It was her pride, while getting ready this table in the morning, not to forget one single necessary article. She learnt them by heart, as she might a poem, and with a corresponding fervour. And though for the first few repetitions she occasionally forgot a line she was soon word-perfect.

Glossary:

Camberwell and Hampstead: London districts

safety-curtain: a fire-proof curtain that can be lowered to cut off the audience in a theatre from the stage

Turn over for Section B

Section B: Poetry

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Read carefully the following poem, 'Old Man', by Edward Thomas, published in 1914 and answer the question that follows.

Write an analysis of this poem, in which you focus on the significance of the representation of the relationship between a father and daughter.

[25 marks]

Old Man

Old Man, or Lad's-Love, - in the name there's nothing
To one that knows not Lad's-Love, or Old Man,
The hoar green feathery herb, almost a tree,
Growing with rosemary and lavender.
Even to one that knows it well, the names
Half decorate, half perplex, the thing it is:
At least, what that is clings not to the names
In spite of time. And yet I like the names.

The herb itself I like not, but for certain
I love it, as someday the child will love it
Who plucks a feather from the door-side bush
Whenever she goes in or out of the house.
Often she waits there, snipping the tips and shrivelling
The shreds at last on to the path,
Thinking perhaps of nothing, till she sniffs
Her fingers and runs off. The bush is still
But half as tall as she, 'though it is as old;
So well she clips it. Not a word she says;
And I can only wonder how much hereafter
She will remember, with that bitter scent,
Of garden rows, and ancient damson trees
Topping a hedge, a bent path to a door
A low thick bush beside the door, and me
Forbidding her to pick.

As for myself,
Where first I met the bitter scent is lost.
I, too, often shrivel the grey shreds,
Sniff them and think and sniff again and try
Once more to think what it is I am remembering,
Always in vain. I cannot like the scent,
Yet I would rather give up others more sweet,
With no meaning, than this bitter one.

I have mislaid the key. I sniff the spray
And think of nothing; I see and I hear nothing;
Yet seem, too, to be listening, lying in wait
For what I should, yet never can, remember;
No garden appears, no path, no hoar-green bush
Of Lad's-love, or Old Man, no child beside,
Neither father nor mother, nor any playmate;
Only an avenue, dark, nameless, without end.

Edward Thomas

Glossary:

Old Man or Lad's-Love, rosemary, lavender: garden herbs

row: a line of plants in a garden

damson: a fruit

hoar: white, or greyish-white, especially with age or frost

END OF QUESTIONS

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